Is Mary Your Mother?

An Invitation to Belong in the Family of Jesus

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Introduction

We all want to belong.

We all come into the world the same way, through a mother - a mother we belong to. The story of the Bible leads to Jesus Christ, who came to bring us into His family. And He came through a Woman, His Mother. Every family has a mother.

My question for you is this:

Is Mary your Mother?

It is a simple question. It is also a question *surprisingly few have ever thought to ask.* If I had only a few seconds to ask you one question, this is the one I would ask.

It is a question about belonging to a family and a home.

"Is Mary your Mother?" is a question at the center of the story the Bible tells. To answer it, you need to know that story.

Chapter 1

The Key to the Story

Everyone wants to belong to something bigger than themselves: to be part of an epic story. But you can't be part of a story if you don't know *what the story is*.

God's story matters more than any other, because it is the one you are living in. It decides who you belong to, who you become, and where you will be forever.

Every great story is held together by its main characters, its theme, and its plot. In God's story, He gives us all three at the very beginning. When you know this, everything else makes sense.

All three are given in one verse, and all of Christianity unfolds from it. But the Bible doesn't spell everything out for you, and no good story does - can you let the story unfold? The best stories are written for you to enter into - will you?

It starts with how you read it.

How to Read the Story

There are two ways people usually read the Bible.

Some read it as God's story, a story about God that they watch from the outside. They read it like a rulebook. When read that way, it asks "do you obey?"

Some read it as a story about me, written for me. They read it like a self-help book. When read that way, it asks "do you admire?" and "what do you prefer?"

Both hold something true. The Bible *is* God's story. And it *is* about you. Each is only half the picture. There is a third way to read it: the way a child reads the story of their home. This way of reading the Bible holds both together. It is God's story, and you are in it.

This is how the Bible is meant to be read: as a story about belonging.

The Fall

In the first book of the Bible, Genesis, we see how it all began. God creates the world and the first humans, Adam and Eve. He places them in a garden called Eden. In the middle of the garden God placed two trees. He told Adam and Eve they could eat from every tree in the garden except one.

Then Satan took the form of a snake. Satan is a fallen angel, the leader of all the fallen angels, who are called demons. They all fell when they told God "No." Satan came to Adam and Eve to get them to say "No" too by eating of the one tree God told them not to. Adam and Eve listened to Satan. They saw that the fruit was good to eat and pleasing to look at. They joined him in saying "No" to God.

Any No to God is what is called "sin."

From that moment on, every human ever born is born under that "No," and under it come sickness, decay and death.

This moment is called The Fall.

The Key to the Bible

And right at that moment, God steps in. God walks into the midst of The Fall and speaks to each one present. When He answers what they have done, He starts with the Serpent, and what He says sets up the rest of the story of the Bible in just one verse.

That verse is Genesis 3:15.

In it you will find:

A woman

Her enemy

Her children

Her Son

> I will put enmity between you and the woman,
>
> and between your seed and her seed;
>
> he shall bruise your head,
>
> and you shall bruise his heel.[1]

The Same Four at the End

Now turn to the end of the Bible, to its last book, Revelation. In Revelation 12, the same characters come back for the end of the story. In it you will find:

A woman

Her enemy

Her children

Her Son

> And a great portent appeared in heaven, a woman clothed with the sun, with the moon under her feet, and on her head

> a crown of twelve stars; she was with child and she cried out in her pangs of birth, in anguish for delivery.
> And another portent appeared in heaven; behold, a great red dragon, with seven heads and ten horns, and seven diadems upon his heads.
> And the dragon stood before the woman who was about to bear a child, that he might devour her child when she brought it forth; she brought forth a male child, one who is to rule all the nations with a rod of iron, but her child was caught up to God and to his throne...
> And the great dragon was thrown down, that ancient serpent, who is called the Devil and Satan, the deceiver of the whole world...
> Then the dragon was angry with the woman, and went off to make war on the rest of her offspring, on those who keep the commandments of God and bear testimony to Jesus.[2]

The same four characters at the beginning of the Bible and at the end is by design. Anyone who reads the Bible looking for its context will find it here. These characters frame the whole story.

The Hidden Link

In Genesis 3:15 and Revelation 12:17 there is a hidden link, one word that was intentionally placed there that the first Christians would see leaping off the page.

The New Testament, including Revelation, was written in Greek. The Old Testament was written in Hebrew, but it was translated into Greek before Jesus was born, and that Greek Bible is the one the first Christians read.

It was never hidden in Greek, only in English. The Greek of both verses uses the very same word. It only gets lost in English, where translations often use two different words.

The significance of this word is deeper when you understand that the Apostle John, one of the 12 Disciples of Jesus, wrote the book of Revelation. John wrote three letters (First, Second and Third John) and a Gospel story of Jesus. In his letters he is famous for calling Christians "little children." It is his signature phrase. He wrote with extraordinary tenderness and love of the family of Jesus. He had such a close relationship with Jesus, that he calls himself in the Gospel that he wrote "the disciple Jesus loved." He never spoke impersonally of Jesus or His family.

In Revelation 12, when John speaks of The Woman's Child, Jesus, he still uses the ordinary Greek word for a child, *teknon* (verses 4 and 5). But in verse 17, John switches words. He switches just this once to the Greek word *sperma*, which means "seed" or "offspring." He isn't doing this to distance or impersonalize the "children" mentioned. He chose it on purpose, because *sperma* is the word Genesis 3:15 uses for The Woman's seed. And this one word deliberately chosen changes how you read the Bible. In English, Genesis says "her seed" and

Revelation says "her offspring," but in Greek they are the same three words:

Verse	Greek	Said aloud	Meaning
Genesis 3:15	τοῦ σπέρματος αὐτῆς	tou spermatos autēs	her seed
Revelation 12:17	τοῦ σπέρματος αὐτῆς	tou spermatos autēs	her seed

When John chose his words about The Woman's children, he was not making an academic point. He was showing the children he wrote to so tenderly where they belong.

John is telling us:

> The Woman's children there in Genesis 3:15 are The Woman's children here in Revelation.

John was telling every Christian:

> You have a Mother.
>
> There has been a Mother at the center of God's story from the beginning.
>
> If you are a Christian, you are one of her children.

This leaps off the page to everyone who reads John's words as a participant, as one of these children instead of a spectator. And when you're invested in the story, that John is the one to tell us this is not a small thing either.

What's more, this one word unlocks everything else in the story:

If her children match, so does everyone else in the story.

The enemy is a serpent in Genesis 3 and a dragon in Revelation 12, and Revelation tells us they are the same being: "that ancient serpent, who is called the Devil and Satan."

The Child in Revelation 12, the one who will "rule all the nations with a rod of iron" and who is "caught up to God and to his throne," is Jesus.

If the Child is Jesus, there is only one woman who gave birth to Him: Mary.

The Woman is Mary.

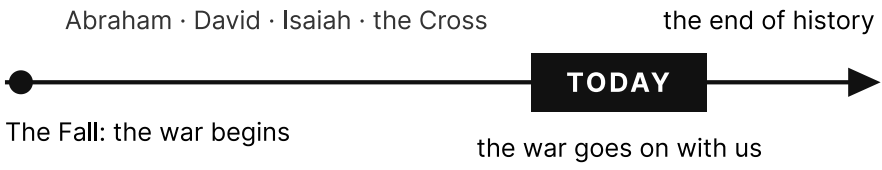
The Enemy is Satan.

Her Son is Jesus.

Her children are Christians, "those who keep the commandments of God and bear testimony to Jesus."

The Same Story

Genesis 3 the first page		Revelation 12 the last pages
A Woman "I will put enmity between you and the woman" (3:15)	*Mary*	**A Woman** "clothed with the sun … a crown of twelve stars" (12:1)
Her Enemy the Serpent (3:1, 3:15)	*Satan*	**Her Enemy** the dragon, "that ancient serpent … Satan" (12:9)
Her Son "he shall bruise your head" (3:15)	*Jesus*	**Her Son** "a male child, one who is to rule all the nations" (12:5)
Her Children "between your seed and her seed" (3:15)	*Christians* same word: seed	**Her Children** "the rest of her seed" (12:17)



Notes **1** Genesis 3:15 **2** Revelation 12:1-5, 9, 17

The story continues in Chapter 2,
The Woman Uncovered.

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